

Could and was able to

Teaching guide

Distinguish past ability from a particular achievement.

Understand the distinction

Could commonly describes a general past ability: At ten, I could swim. For an actual achievement on one particular occasion, was/were able to or managed to is usually clearer: We were able to catch the last train.

The distinction is not absolute. Could is natural for particular past perceptions or mental states: I could hear music. Could not can describe a specific failure: I could not open the door. Could also expresses possibility and polite requests in other contexts.

Compare the patterns

GENERAL ABILITY

I could read when I was five.

A skill at a past age.

ACHIEVEMENT

We managed to finish before noon.

A successful result on an occasion.

PERCEPTION

I could hear the train coming.

A natural use for a particular past perception.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for a general childhood skill: I ___ swim at seven.

2. Express a successful one-off result: We ___ get the last two tickets.

3. Is I could hear a bell outside natural?

Use it in your own life

Write one general past ability and one particular success.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. could

Was able to is also possible, but could is concise and usual.

2. were able to / managed to

These forms clearly report an actual achievement.

3. Yes. Could commonly occurs with perception verbs.

Do not apply the achievement rule to every past use.

One possible response

I could cycle when I was young. Yesterday I managed to repair a flat tire.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-35.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write one general past ability and one particular success.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.